While she was grappling with the stark reality that her husband was gone forever, on the seventh day of his death, she got a call requesting her to meet Ratan at the Taj President. During the meeting, she told Ratan how lost, desperate and hopeless she felt. But he changed everything, she says. ‘His kind words made me so confident. I remember the words he told me. He told me, “Mrs Martis, I won’t be able to give your husband back, but I will not leave you until your death,”’ she remembers. From then on, she says, she found meaning in life. ‘I felt fortunate because I got the confidence that there is somebody to hold me even if I fall. And this credit goes to Ratan Tata. He took care of my children and me. Ratan Tata did whatever he promised.’

The Taj continues to pay Agnes her husband’s salary and takes care of her medical requirements. The company gave her a job with the TPSWT and paid for her children’s complete education in full. This was besides the compensation and other benefits she received. Her life was completely transformed. Her son, Floyd Faustine Martis, who was in class ten when his father was shot dead, went on to get an engineering degree and later landed a job with L&T Infotech. The Taj even offered to finance his MBA degree, but Floyd found his job too exciting to leave it for higher studies, his mother says with unconcealed pride.

Agnes’s daughter, Priya Florence, was already employed with the Taj before the attacks. She managed to get out safely that night. After her father’s death, she completed her MBA with full financial support from the Taj. The administration even allowed her flexible working hours while she was studying, and she topped her course. And when she got married to an engineer in Dubai, the Taj transferred her to its hotel in the city. ‘When I requested P.V. Murthy, the vice president of the Taj Group [to transfer her daughter], he posted her immediately. The Taj family is like that. They took care of all our needs,’ says an excited Agnes.

Hardly able to contain her happiness, she says, ‘Do you know Kamdhenu [a sacred cow that grants wishes]? The Taj is like that [for me]. If God [were to take human form] God will be like him [Ratan], so kind, so generous. I do not know if it is right or wrong, but for me, he is God.’

**Extending Relief**